

120-DAY ENTRY PLAN • FRACTIONAL CHIEF AI OFFICER

Diagnose fast. Decide deliberately. Transfer from the beginning.

An illustrative operating plan designed to be recalibrated to the client's mandate, sector, risk, technical estate, and executive capacity.

The first 120 days should create a board-governable mandate, a small evidence-bearing portfolio, and an operating system that can transfer to permanent ownership.

PRINCIPLES

Mandate before volume Do not expand the use-case list until outcomes, authority, portfolio logic, and guardrails are explicit.	Work before theater Attach AI to real workflow decisions, roles, handoffs, economics, and consequences.	Evidence before scale Define what will justify scale, redesign, hold, or stop before the pilot becomes politically permanent.
Governance in the design Human authority, data, evaluation, fallback, vendor accountability, and exception handling are part of the product.	Adoption has an owner Training is not adoption. Name the workflow owner, behavior change, reinforcement, and feedback mechanism.	Handoff starts on day one Build cadence, records, talent, and decision rights so progress can survive the engagement.

DAY 120 SUCCESS CONDITION

ASSET	WHAT EXISTS	WHAT NO LONGER DEPENDS ON THE FRACTIONAL LEADER
Mandate	Outcome, authority, portfolio, guardrails, adoption, continuity	Executive interpretation of priorities
Portfolio	Funded work, owners, evidence, technical posture, stop/scale logic	Ad hoc prioritization
Governance	Policy, review, exceptions, human authority, monitoring	Informal risk decisions
Operating cadence	Decision forums, scorecard, issue escalation, learning	Personality-based coordination
Talent and handoff	Permanent owner, team shape, hiring or capability plan	External executive dependency

Days 1-60

AXIAL | SEARCH

BOUND
THE
MANDATE
·
CHOOSE
THE
PORTFOLIO

Russell Dudek <https://russelldudek.github.io/Axial/>

DAYS 1-30 · BOUND THE MANDATE

WORKSTREAM	ACTIONS	OUTPUT
Executive context	Interview sponsor, board or committee representation, functional leaders, technology, data, risk, legal, security, and finance.	Mandate hypotheses and decision-rights map
Workflow reality	Observe a small number of high-consequence workflows; identify friction, rework, judgment, data, exceptions, and owner behavior.	Workflow opportunity and consequence map
Current AI estate	Inventory production, pilot, vendor, employee-led, and shadow AI use; review architecture, data, contracts, cost, and ownership.	AI estate and exposure register
Value and risk baseline	Define available operating measures, economic units, customer or employee consequences, and governance gaps.	Baseline evidence and measurement plan
Mandate charter	Draft Outcome, Authority, Portfolio, Guardrails, Adoption, and Continuity clauses.	Board-ready charter v1

Decision gate at day 30: Is the organization ready to fund and govern a focused portfolio, or must the engagement first repair sponsorship, authority, data, or operating capacity?

DAYS 31-60 · CHOOSE THE PORTFOLIO

Prioritize

- Value and strategic relevance
- Workflow owner and adoption burden
- Data and technical readiness
- Risk and human authority
- Reuse and learning potential

Decide technical posture

- Build, buy, partner, or defer
- Agent, assist, automate, or keep human-led
- Vendor accountability and exit conditions
- Evaluation, cost, latency, fallback
- Integration and ownership boundaries

Install governance

- Acceptable use and access
- Data and source controls
- Human review and release authority
- Exceptions and escalation
- Monitoring and decision records

Mobilize owners

- Executive sponsor
- Business and workflow owner
- Technical and data owner
- Risk, legal, security, finance
- Adoption and enablement owner

Days 61-120

AXIAL | SEARCH

PROVE
THE
OPERATING
MODEL
·
TRANSFER
THE
SYSTEM

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DAYS 61-90 · PROVE THE OPERATING MODEL

OBJECTIVE	MECHANISM	EVIDENCE
Move selected work	Launch one or two workflow implementations with named owners and complete authority/control design.	Working state, not presentation state
Test the whole system	Exercise normal work, exceptions, human override, fallback, vendor failure, and data-quality conditions.	Evaluation and recovery evidence
Build adoption	Co-design with users, create role-based enablement, capture friction, and review repeated use.	Behavior and workflow measures
Review economics	Track build/run cost, avoided effort, operating impact, customer or employee consequences, and capacity.	Scale/hold/stop recommendation
Coach owners	Run the cadence with internal leaders increasingly owning preparation, decisions, escalation, and follow-through.	Owner-readiness signal

DAYS 91-120 · TRANSFER THE SYSTEM

Confirm the permanent mandate

Clarify whether AI remains a dedicated executive mandate, moves into technology/product/operations, or requires a permanent CAIO search.

Transfer decision cadence

Internal owners run portfolio review, governance exceptions, value evidence, technical choices, adoption issues, and board reporting.

Set the talent sequence

Define executive, product, engineering, data, governance, enablement, and operating roles in the order the portfolio needs them.

Make the engagement decision

Extend for a bounded next mandate, convert to permanent leadership, transfer to the owner, or close because the system is stable.

Final 120-day readout: What are we trying to change? What have we chosen not to do? Can we govern the portfolio? Is adoption becoming durable? Who owns the mandate next? Each answer must point to a named owner and operating evidence, not a future aspiration.